



CARLIN STIEHL For The Times

3 KILLED IN WESTWOOD CRASH

A car hit a bicyclist Thursday and then slammed into a 99 Ranch Market a block away, trapping multiple people beneath it, according to the LAFD. Two men and a woman died at the scene. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

URGENCY RAMPS UP IN GUTHRIE CASE

Credence is given to reports of a ransom note for mother of ‘Today’ show host.

By GRACE TOOHEY, RICHARD WINTON AND CLARA HARTER

Five days into the suspected abduction of Savannah Guthrie’s mother from her Tucson-area home, the urgency to find her has only increased as missed medication and a ransom letter loom over the case.

At a news conference Thursday morning, law enforcement officials appeared to give legitimacy to reports there was a ransom note for the “Today” show host’s mother, citing a deadline Thursday and a second on Monday if the first deadline was not met. And, officials said, Nancy Guthrie appears to still be without vital medication.

“There has been no proof of life,” Heith Janke, the special agent in charge of the FBI’s Phoenix division, said. “Time is of the essence.”

He said authorities are still investigating a ransom letter sent to local and national media outlets requesting financial compensation for Guthrie’s return, but at this point they are “taking it seriously.”

Law enforcement sources, who spoke to The Times on the condition of anonymity, said the ransom note contained at least two details about Guthrie’s home that hadn’t been made public.

Nancy’s son, Camron Guthrie, issued a video pleading with the kidnapper Thursday afternoon, around the time of the ransom letter’s first deadline. “Whoever is out there holding our mother, we want to hear from you,” he said. “We haven’t heard anything directly. We need you to reach out and we need a way to communicate with you so we can move forward.”

On Wednesday, Savannah Guthrie and her siblings shared a heartbreaking video appearing to plead with their mother’s potential captors.

“We live in a world where voices and images are easily manipulated. We need to know, without a doubt, that she is alive and that you have her,” Savannah Guthrie said in the video shared on Instagram. “We want to hear from you, and we are ready to listen. Please reach out to us.”

In a direct message to her mom, she said: “We will not rest, your children will not

[See Guthrie, A12]

UCLA fires DEI director over posts on Kirk’s death

By Jaweed Kaleem

In the days after Charlie Kirk was fatally shot in September while speaking at a Utah college campus, stunned followers of his conservative movement mourned online, condemning political violence. From his Los Angeles home, Johnathan Perkins, a Black diversity, equity and inclusion director at UCLA, had a different take.

“Good riddance,” he wrote on Bluesky. In another post: “It is OKAY to be happy when someone who hated you and called for your people’s death dies — even if they are murdered.”

Later: “I’m always glad when bigots die.”

Perkins said he was exercising his right to free speech on his own time about

a divisive public figure. Screenshots of his posts spread across conservative news sites and social media. He received online death threats. Complaints poured into UCLA inboxes.

Officials swiftly placed Perkins on paid leave and opened an investigation. UCLA also issued a rare statement about an employee: “Violence of any kind — including the celebration of it — is completely unacceptable and will not be tolerated.”

Last week, UCLA fired him, and his last day on the payroll was Friday.

The termination letter, which Perkins allowed The Times to review, cited violations of policies on “workplace violence

[See UCLA, A8]

Bonta denounces Trump’s fraud claims

The attorney general notes efforts by state have recovered nearly \$2.7 billion since 2016.

By SUHAUNA HUSSAIN AND CLARA HARTER

With the Trump administration reportedly in talks to create an anti-fraud task force for California, state Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta on Thursday vehemently denounced what he described

as the administration’s “reckless” and “false” rhetoric about fraud plaguing the state.

At a news conference at the Ronald Reagan State Building in downtown Los Angeles, Bonta said the Trump administration’s claims that state programs are overrun by fraud and that its government was itself perpetrating or facilitating this fraud was “outrageous and ridiculous and without basis.”

Bonta said most states struggle with some fraud

from outside actors, saying that “anywhere there’s money flowing there’s a risk” and that the state’s Department of Justice has thrown immense resources into cracking down on illicit activities and recovering funds for taxpayers.

As a politicized national fight over waste, fraud and abuse led by Republicans has targeted California and its Democratic leadership, Bonta and other state officials have moved swiftly to combat the claims.

In California, Bonta said,

authorities have recovered nearly \$2.7 billion through criminal and civil prosecutions since 2016, including some \$740 million through Medi-Cal fraud-related prosecutions, about \$2 billion under the state’s False Claims Act, and an additional \$108 million from a task force focused on rooting out tax fraud in the underground economy.

State authorities have frequently partnered with the federal government in the past on such investigations

[See Bonta, A6]

Last arms pact ends for U.S., Russia

By VLADIMIR ISACHENKOV

MOSCOW — The Kremlin said Thursday that it regretted the expiration of the last remaining nuclear arms pact between Russia and the United States, and President Trump declared he was against keeping its limits and wants a better deal.

The pact’s termination left no caps on the two largest atomic arsenals for the first time in more than half a century, fueling fears of an unconstrained nuclear arms race.

Russian President Vladimir Putin last year declared his readiness to stick to the treaty’s limits for another year if Washington followed suit, but Trump has ignored the offer and argued that he wants China to be a part of a new pact — something Beijing has rebuffed.

“Rather than extend ‘NEW START’ [A badly negotiated deal by the United States that, aside from everything else, is being grossly violated], we should have our Nuclear Experts work on a new, improved, and modernized Treaty that can last long into the future,” Trump posted on his social media website.

Putin discussed the pact’s expiration with Chinese leader Xi Jinping on Wednesday, noting the U.S. failure to respond to his proposal to extend its limits and saying that Russia “will act in a balanced and responsible manner based on thorough analysis of the security situation,” Kremlin advisor Yuri Ushakov said.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Moscow views the treaty’s expiration Thursday “negatively” and

[See Treaty, A4]

Down to the wire, mayoral slate still in flux

Lineup of candidates in L.A. is unusually fluid as Saturday filing deadline approaches.

By DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

The race for Los Angeles mayor has been in an extraordinary state of flux, with the candidate lineup shuffling and reshuffling in the final days before the filing deadline.

On Thursday, former schools Supt. Austin Beutner dropped out of the race, citing the death of his 22-year-old daughter. Hours later, L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath said she was still deciding whether to launch her own challenge against Mayor Karen Bass.

Meanwhile, billionaire real estate developer Rick Caruso, who announced last month that he wasn’t running, briefly reemerged as a possible candidate, saying Wednesday that he hadn’t completely ruled it

out. The following day, he changed course yet again, deciding not to enter the race after all.

Pomona College politics professor Sara Sadhwani said she has never seen so many major candidates on the fence about a mayoral bid so close to the filing deadline, which is noon on Saturday.

Although Horvath would seriously shake up the race, she would need to raise a significant amount of money in a short time, Sadhwani said.

“It appears to me that there are a lot of campaign donors sitting out of this race until now, waiting to see who will jump in,” she added.

The uncertainty doesn’t end there. Maryam Zar, who formed a community group to help guide the recovery from the Palisades fire, is also weighing a mayoral bid — and doesn’t plan to decide until the final day.

“It’s not an easy decision,” the Palisades resident said. “I have a life. I’m a parent. I started a nonprofit doing excellent work out of thin air.”

[See Campaign, A6]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

A SIGN at the city clerk’s office directs people filing to run for office. The deadline is at noon on Saturday.

MILAN-CORTINA OLYMPICS

ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

U.S. DEFEATS CZECHS

Alex Carpenter, left, and the U.S. squad celebrate a first-period goal against the Czech team at the Milan-Cortina Games on Thursday. **SPORTS, B10**

Feds support Palisades rebuild

Visiting White House officials vow to speed up permitting, a core state and local function. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Not as warm. L.A. Basin: 71/50. **B6**

Markets

Opinion Voices

Graffiti Towers closer to cleanup

Judge OKs bankruptcy exit for L.A. complex, paving the way for possible sale. **BUSINESS, A10**

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